Von der Leyen eyes curbs on Chinese chemicals, machinery next

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Von der Leyen eyes curbs on Chinese chemicals, machinery next
By Camille Gijs, Carlo Martuscelli, Hans von der Burchard · Oct 15, 2026, 3:56 PM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — The EU will prioritize chemicals and industrial machinery in its efforts to protect European industry from Chinese competition, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen told EU leaders on Thursday.

The Commission is looking at ways to protect the two sectors, von der Leyen said during a closed-door session at the European Council, two people with knowledge of the discussion told POLITICO. She said safeguards were the most effective tools currently available to the EU because they could be applied quickly and broadly.

Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič struck a deal with Beijing last week that would cap annual imports of Chinese hybrid cars at 350,000 units next year — less than half of expected deliveries this year. Leaders have called for further sectors to be protected from surging Chinese imports, as the bilateral trade deficit continues to grow.

EU manufacturers are under pressure from low-priced imports from China, leading to a spate of layoffs and factory closures across the bloc.

Speaking in Beijing last week, Šefčovič said the deal on hybrid cars would serve as a “blueprint” for other sectors. A senior Commission official said on Monday that the Commission had also heard complaints about Chinese imports from the wind and furniture industries.

Commission officials have been working on safeguard measures for plastics and epoxy resins, but no investigation, which would precede any trade measures, has been formally launched.

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